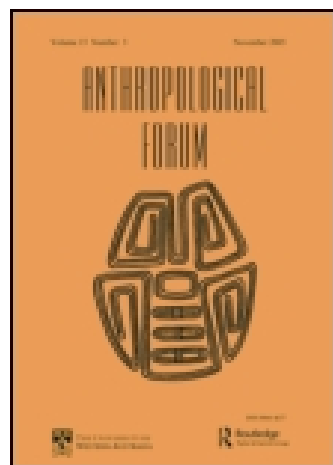


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The Critical Ethnographer as Trickster

Toon van Meijl

The polaristic structure of the psyche ... like any other energetic system [is] dependent on the tension of opposites. (Jung 1956, 209)

In this paper, I explore and elaborate similarities between the identity of mythological tricksters and ethnographic field researchers. As tricksters have multiple identities to mediate the unmediated (Basso 1996), so anthropologists adopt different identities in the field to reconcile the irreconcilable demands that are essential to ethnography. Participant observation reinforces the need to be flexible and to operate contextually. It requires anthropologists to engage in complex social realities and to detach themselves from the perplexities arising from their involvement in the social field of informants. The position of an anthropologist is ambiguous, but the tension between involvement and detachment may also be the secret behind anthropology's insights into cultural and social dynamics.

In the contemporary circumstances of globalisation, postmodernity and post-colonialism, it is increasingly cumbersome to conduct classical field research in the sense of becoming involved in the social practices of informants while simultaneously keeping a distance. Informants frequently request, if not command, anthropologists to attune their research directly to local interests and to support indigenous agendas. Yet the profession of anthropology also demands those of us who are both consultants and ethnographers to step back from intensive engagement and situate the interests of informants in context.

There are anthropological dilemmas posed by the differing expectations, demands and interests of anthropologists and their informants. I elaborate these, first, by reflecting on my research among New Zealand Maori and showing how I attempted to reconcile my identities of development consultant and overseas anthropologist; and, second, by evaluating my decision to adopt a dual identity as both advocate and critical ethnographer, in contrast to New Zealand anthropologists, who tend either to support Maori political agendas unconditionally or to opt out. My argument is that the dual identity of trickster, advocating involvement and detachment, political support and contextual criticism, provides a reasonable resolution of the dilemmas confronting postmodern and postcolonial anthropology.

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Ethnographic Field Research in New Zealand

In New Zealand, the ethnic opposition between the Maori minority and the settler-descendant majority politicises ethnographic practice. This is reflected in a number of issues that contribute to the ambiguity and paradoxical character of New Zealand anthropology: (1) the paucity of recent ethnographic field studies of Maori; (2) Maori hostility towards social anthropology; (3) a cultural renaissance in Maori development and political discourses; and (4) the contestation of hegemonic representations of Maori culture and tradition within Maori society.

The first paradox confronted me during my fieldwork preparations in the early 1980s. Although Biggs (1960, 2) had noted that Maori were one of the best-documented peoples, most of the nineteenth-century literature is historically, ethnologically and philologically oriented. This situation did not change significantly in the course of the twentieth century, and, in 2000, a University of Auckland colleague described contemporary Maori as the most under-researched people in the world. Why have so few anthropologists written recently on Maori? The answer is twofold.

First, nineteenth-century Maori had been largely dispossessed of their lands, causing significant migration to urban areas in search of employment. By the early 1980s, approximately 75 per cent of Maori were living in cities. They no longer lived in the isolated villages that were attractive to anthropologists as bounded fieldwork sites. Second, urban Maori never flourished economically and, from the 1970s, high unemployment, low income, poor health and high crime rates characterised Maori life. Maori increasingly protested against their conditions. Maori voices against anthropological research also became louder. In this context, European attitudes, considered imperial and self-aggrandising, were associated with social anthropology. Anthropologists were seen to justify their behaviour in the name of 'science' by coming, taking and leaving without reciprocating.

While Maori people were largely hostile towards social anthropology, most had not met anthropologists because of an absence of fieldwork. A second paradox, then, emerges from the question of why the discipline featured so prominently in Maori caricatures of the non-Maori or Pakeha world. We must analyse this question, of course, in relation to anthropology's association with primitivism and exoticism (Keesing 1989). Interestingly, the ostensibly unfounded Maori suspicion of social anthropology appeared itself to be ambivalent. Thus, it was remarkable that a handful of Maori graduates had completed university degrees in linguistics or social anthropology (Fitzgerald 1977). This suggested that Maori were not necessarily hostile to anthropology, but to the practice of anthropology in some circumstances by certain kinds of people.

Ironically, I was welcomed easily into a dynamic Maori community in the centre of the North Island to conduct fieldwork. I was able to contact a powerful Maori chief and anthropologist who was raising political consciousness in his own community. He seemed intrigued by my research question, based on Godelier (1978): To what

extent do Maori people consent to their disadvantaged position in New Zealand by not resisting it? Additionally, the anthropologically trained Maori leader of the community was pursuing a political agenda in which anthropology could play a role in advancing Maori development. My unreserved support of Maori development strategies of the community leadership was assumed.

In the third paradox, this politically progressive viewpoint, concerned with the future of young Maori people, contrasted with cultural notions dominating Maori political discourse, which were based on a distant past. To illustrate, during my fieldwork I lived on a Maori *marae*, a ceremonial centre. In the past, most Maori people lived on or around a *marae*, but, since people had migrated to urban areas, most *marae* became isolated sanctuaries of traditional Maori culture. People would move onto *marae* only for ceremonial purposes.

This *marae* was exceptional for two reasons. Approximately 300 people were living in its vicinity and, at the same time, the leadership of the community had reconceptualised the *marae* by extending its social functions, particularly for young people. It ran special education programs, because more than 50 per cent of Maori youngsters leave school without any qualifications and have few chances of finding employment. The *marae* management had successfully applied for government funding to operate second-chance education programs for young Maori people based on the conviction that they would feel more at ease on a *marae*. However, this was not obvious.

Youngsters enrolled in the programs varied in motivation, interest and ability, but shared the same cultural background. Paradoxically, however, they were unfamiliar with the Maori language and could not participate in ceremonial gatherings, of which they had limited knowledge. Most had rarely visited a *marae*, so that the programs' training in Maori language and culture entailed their first encounter with classic Maori culture. This brought about feelings of embarrassment and alienation from the culture that was ideologically considered theirs, yet was far removed from their personal experiences (van Meijl 2001).

Thus, a fourth paradox confronted me: the construction of Maori culture was contested. It was defined primarily with reference to its expressive aspects, such as ceremonies, arts and crafts. This restricted concept emerged at the turn of the twentieth century, largely based on European ethnographic accounts of Maori society during the final quarter of the nineteenth century (van Meijl 1996). Revived for political reasons, it justified Maori demands for the return of sovereignty. Its ideological function is apparent when compared and contrasted with the cultural practices of young urban Maori people. Their culture is based not on traditions but on the likelihood that they will be unemployed, with low self-esteem and few aspirations for the future. Appealing to their responsibility to learn a culture associated with a past era might not improve the socioeconomic position of young Maori.

When I drew the attention of the leaders to the discrepancy between their construction of culture and the experiences of the young people, they told me: 'They still have to learn where they come from and where they belong.' The young people

did not want to learn, however. Generally, they felt they could never emulate the skills of the old people in language and ceremonies. They were interested more in wrestling, motorcycling, skateboarding or soap operas than in traditional mythology and genealogy. The cultural differences between the leadership and the trainees placed me in a dilemma: the leadership expected me to reproduce their cultural projects but, as an anthropologist, I was especially interested in the contradictions that emerged from the confrontation between those cultural projects and the practices of Maori youngsters. Similarly, the leadership claimed to represent the entire society, but my anthropological background pointed me to internal variations within Maori society.

Deviations from the leadership's strategy were considered counter to development. What, then, is the anthropologist's commitment? A political commitment is increasingly demanded from anthropologists working in politicised circumstances, but should anthropologists be committed politically to their sponsors? To what extent does a political commitment to a certain group of people presuppose that societies are not internally stratified or divided about certain issues? Moreover, to what extent does a political commitment to any group of people imply a critical detachment from other groups within the same society? Is it a task of anthropologists to engage with their interlocutors to such an extent that the representations of ethnographic circumstances with paradoxical, if not contradictory, dimensions are compromised? Faced with waves of migration in a global world and the rise of multiculturalism in modern nation-states, these questions are certain to dominate anthropological agendas in the near future.

Multiculturalism and Pakeha Ethnicity

Multiculturalism is an epiphenomenon of globalisation, and as such signals a crisis in the definition of nations, but also of cultural groupings aspiring to nationhood, such as Maori. Maori are no longer the only minority in New Zealand, which has welcomed many immigrants from various countries. In most countries, multiculturalism is understood as a demand for social and economic advancement by cultural minorities. In New Zealand, however, the largest minority, Maori, who comprise 15 per cent of the total population, argue that multiculturalism will undermine their status as indigenous people by reducing them to one of many minorities (Pearson 1995, 18–22). Maori have rejected multiculturalism so strongly that the state has officially adopted a policy of biculturalism. Anthropologists are ambivalent about this policy, since it forces them to mediate their political commitment to multiculturalism and their solidarity with Maori.

The notion of biculturalism assumes the existence of two cultures, Maori and Pakeha. Yet the 'two cultures' debate is suspect, as reflected in discussions about the meaning of Pakeha. Etymologically, Pakeha derives from the Maori adjective for 'foreign', and originally referred to all non-Maori, but Maori people now tend to use the term for New Zealanders of European descent only, who themselves have been

reluctant to use the term self-ascriptively. Since the 1980s, however, a small group has begun to use the term self-referentially in response to Maori activism. This has raised the question of the meaning of Pakeha ethnicity (Barber 1999).

Some see Pakeha as 'an indigenous New Zealand expression that denotes things that belong to New Zealand via one major stream of its heritage: people, manners, values, and customs that are not exclusively Polynesian ... [b]ut ... also ... *no longer simply European*' (King 1991, 16; emphasis in original). King thus defines Pakeha as a cultural identity that is based on the indigenous culture in New Zealand, although he adds that it will not displace or supplant Maori culture (p. 20). An essential aspect of Pakeha ethnicity is, rather, 'contact with and being affected by Maori things: Maori concepts, Maori values, Maori language and Maori relationships' (p. 19), with which he subordinates Pakeha culture to Maori culture. Sociologist Paul Spoonley (1991), on the other hand, argues that Pakeha is not a cultural identity, but rather a political identity held by those Pakeha who support a bicultural partnership with Maori and who recognise their rights as the indigenous people of New Zealand. They use the concept of Pakeha to express their commitment to a set of political obligations that involve the sharing of power with Maori.

In spite of differing views, King and Spoonley share a striking sense of self-effacement in relation to Maori, a view also reflected in New Zealand anthropology. I would argue that this partly explains the absence of recent ethnography on the Maori.

New Zealand Anthropology

Early in the 1980s, some graduate students advocated an 'indigenous style of anthropology in New Zealand which is free of all colonial and neocolonial connotations' (e.g., Ryan 1982). The graduate student campaign soon received support from a senior New Zealand anthropologist, Anne Salmond (1986), who extended the argument theoretically.

Anthropology carried out according to European styles of analysis is, according to Salmond (1986, 45), 'a political act in the regional society'. She urged New Zealanders to conduct a new 'local anthropology' that would actively advance biculturalism and acknowledge that New Zealand is politically a Pacific country. She also appealed to anthropologists to resolve the conflicting histories of Maori and Pakeha.

Salmond (1986, 46) did acknowledge the difficulty of the project by opining that 'perhaps, in research expressive of both traditions, commissioned and guided by Maori groups, in fully collaborative relationships, it may be done'. In her proposal, there is only room for Pakeha scholars, as opposed to overseas anthropologists, while at the same time she proposes to limit anthropological scholarship to research that is 'commissioned and guided by Maori groups'. This reticent attitude of Pakeha towards Maori leaves open how the contradictions between Maori and Pakeha might be resolved on an equal basis.

The question we face in the multiculturalist era is probably how social anthropology will meet the increasing demand for cultural respect and political support without relinquishing its autonomy. Clearly, I do not favour reinstalling anthropology's imperial control of social relationships in the field, but, at the same time, I am hesitant to entrust anthropology to the hands of our interlocutors, particularly because some may operate mainly in favour of their own interests (van Meijl 2000a). Then, anthropology would be unable to resolve the ambiguities characterising the ethnographic field in a global world. After all, anthropology would lose its 'stranger's value' if we uncritically accepted the political conditions imposed by our interlocutors (e.g., Smith 1999), as Salmond suggests. Nevertheless, in New Zealand, anthropological representations of contemporary Maori are either nonexistent or sufficiently politically correct to add little to our understanding of the dynamics of the field. How might ethnography resolve the tension between political support and critical ethnography?

The Anthropologist as Trickster

We must never lose sight of the multidimensional context of ethnographic practice, with its ambiguities, paradoxes and contradictions, and anthropologists should maintain their autonomy as professional strangers. This does not necessarily imply that anthropologists should never identify with a particular dimension, interest or group. We have an obligation to reciprocate and sometimes to support the political agendas of our interlocutors, but simultaneously we should diversify, rather than homogenise, their interests in ethnographic practices. We also have an obligation to place our political activities in context, in order not to lose recognition of our insights as 'professional strangers' (Agar 1996). A social anthropologist is, therefore, ambiguous and equivocal, if not unreliable, from the perspective of politically engaged informants aspiring to a single political purpose, that is, to enhance self-determination.

The position of an anthropologist resembles the role of tricksters in myths, particularly those narrated in Austronesia. The Maori demigod, Maui, is a fine example of a trickster. Maui was a culture hero who linked gods and man, and therefore he was ambiguous by definition. Every trickster in mythology is equivocal and even unreliable in this mediating role. Why and how, then, might a trickster provide a model for anthropology, a social science that often pretends to be unambiguous and unequivocal?

A seminal paper by Jan Pouwer (1978) suggests an answer by referring to the central position of the concepts of ambiguity and ambivalence in the school of structural anthropology in the Netherlands. In an early article by De Josselin de Jong, 'The origin of the divine trickster' (1929), these concepts first emerge as crucial. This study of the divine trickster is based on a comparative analysis of ancient mythology. De Josselin de Jong's most appealing case study centres on the enigmatic Greek culture hero and cunning trickster, Hermes. He is associated with life and death, the

underworld and the upper world, while he cannot be distinguished from an archaic androgynous god, because of which he is effectively bisexual. In theoretical terms, Pouwer (1978, 208) has argued that Hermes, as any other trickster, 'combines an either-or position with a both-and one', and that it is 'the very combination of the two positions which enables him to represent a polyvalent, ambivalent totality' (see also Crapanzano 1986).

The trickster may be regarded as the embodiment of totality, while at the same time occupying a neutral position. This is precisely why the position of social anthropologists in the current era is strikingly similar to the role of the divine trickster in mythology. Social anthropologists who sympathise with the political ideals of local societies and peoples may well opt to act as advocates or mediators of their political programs. At the same time, they may or may not also step back and reflect on the construction, development and implementation of indigenous political strategies, and the relationship between politics and culture, as well as the internal differentiation in perspectives on these topics (Pels 2000, 136). This strategy also characterises my own work, which is supportive of Maori development and historical claims, while critically reflexive of political ambiguities. We must never compromise the political purposes of indigenous peoples, but in most situations there is sufficient scope for sophisticated mediation between indigenous and anthropological agendas. The anthropologist who engages in politics and scholarship is not a traitor, but rather a trickster, someone who embodies different roles in different contexts and combines both in the practice of what I would label critical ethnography.

Are ambiguity and ambivalence acceptable to science? Karl Popper's (1963) positivist logic still applies to popular discourse on science and the allegedly objective role of academics. In consequence, social anthropologists often think they have only one option left in the increasingly politicised field, which is to seek refuge in a position opposite to positivism, one that is profoundly predicated on a political agenda. Absolute identification with the political agenda of our informants, however, must not release us from our moral obligation to the discipline and to ourselves, which implies the need to place our field research in context and reflect on the political position of our interlocutors, their relationship with us, and the impact of this relationship on the results of our research (Strathern 2000). Only these aspects can make ethnography of critical value.

Ethics and Inequality

Elsewhere (van Meijl 2000b), I have clarified and justified my work as a social anthropologist in terms of a moral philosophical viewpoint, disputing demands to abide by quasi-universal rules as established in professional codes of ethics, and highlighting people's primary responsibility to their own moral self. Here, it is necessary to translate the moral philosophical validation of anthropological scholarship into the terms of the debate on ethnography and politics in New

Zealand and elsewhere. Hence, I briefly elaborate my personal political motivation as a social anthropologist.

I was determined to contribute to the emancipation of Maori, and I cannot detach this motivation from the history of the discipline. In the past, social anthropology centred largely on the study of inequality and even influenced other disciplines' approaches to inequality (Tilly 2001). In recent decades, however, social anthropology has lost its status as source of inspiration for the study of inequality. To some extent, this is the result of the collapse of communism and the demise of Marxism as epistemological paradigm. We may interpret recent world history as having winnowed the works of Marx to make it possible again, without being a Marxist, to perpetuate their relevance for anthropological theory (Roseberry 1997). Maurice Godelier (2000, 311–12) has also summarised the Marxist legacy for the study of society, and has emphasised that 'individuals and groups occupy distinct and usually unequal positions with regard to their access to the material, intellectual, and social conditions of existence in society'.

I would argue that these statements apply to New Zealand society as well as to Maori society. Structural inequality characterises Maori and Pakeha relations. Simultaneously, social relations within Maori society are likewise embedded in a structural hierarchy between individuals and groups (van Meijl 1994). My interest and commitment also concerns inequalities within Maori society, between chiefs and ordinary people, between older and younger people, between males and females and between (rural) tribes and (urban) pan-tribes. Of course, we must read the interpretation and analysis of unequal relations in Maori society in context, but it is unacceptable to neglect internal Maori hierarchy because it may compromise Maori strategies to resolve inequality between Maori and Pakeha. One form of inequality cannot be justified by giving exclusive preference in politics to another form of inequality. Social anthropologists are normally both involved and detached in their field, but for the same reason they are also neither, and therefore their status is highly ambiguous because of the varying loyalties that come to the surface in different contexts.

The shifting spectrum of hierarchy and inequality inside and outside Maori society also raises the question of anthropology's audience (see also Petersen this issue). For whom are we writing? For which Maori are we writing? In view of my argument that anthropological observers have a responsibility not only to support the victims of colonialism but also to comprehend and address the plurality of political voices in colonial and postcolonial societies, it is not surprising that the audience of anthropology is dependent on context. Multiple groupings within a society make it necessary to address multiple audiences. It is unavoidable not only to support the interests of the weakest interlocutors in all contexts but also to compare and contrast different perspectives on the same situation, and to deconstruct them in relation to different audiences as only partial truths (Clifford 1986).

The inherent ambiguity of the ethnographic field and the epistemological requirement to address multiple audiences also imply that neither political advocacy

nor native anthropology provides a better alternative to the multidimensional approach of critical ethnography. Advocacy may address inequality more directly than critical ethnography, but, by supporting the interests of one particular group, it leaves aside the necessity to understand the diversified context of conflicting interests in order to resolve *all* forms of inequality (Hastrup and Elsass 1990). Native anthropologists claim to have privileged access to a more valid knowledge of their society, but, in view of the postmodernist rejection of absolute knowledge, no grounds for privileging any account or rejecting any representation over any other at present exist (Narayan 1993).

The Lonely Anthropologist

In conclusion, the capitalisation of ambiguity in social anthropology will remain difficult to explain to outsiders for a long time to come. Nevertheless, I think the position of trickster ensnares us, even when our field circumstances might become less politicised in the unforeseeable future. After all, the role of trickster does not only apply to the politicised field in the contemporary world, but is also an intrinsic part of the identity of any ethnographic fieldworker. For the same reason, my suggestion that the concept of the anthropologist as trickster provides a useful model for reflection on the position of ethnographic field researchers is not simply a cop-out. Instead, I maintain that the notion of trickster is inherent to the practice of anthropology, regardless of politics, since social anthropologists doing ethnography are invariably caught between the dimensions of involvement and detachment (Elias 1956). Involvement and detachment constitute the ultimate poles of the continuum between participation and observation, which is methodologically imbalanced by definition. Indeed, if ethnography is not to lose its critical value, it is essential to maintain the status of 'stranger' by detaching ourselves from the field at the same time as we become involved. In my view, critical ethnography is grounded in this epistemological tension brought about by our discipline's research methodology.

Finally, by coquetting with our professional identity as stranger, we do not intend to idealise it. Many established fieldworkers have reflected on the implications of anthropological practice for their identity. Most did so in personal diaries, of which Malinowski's (1967) posthumously published memoirs are probably the most famous. These demonstrated that an essential aspect of an anthropological identity is loneliness, which Malinowski, like others, found difficult to accept. Experienced social anthropologists will recognise their own identity struggles in Malinowski's dilemmas. Indeed, loneliness is central to critical ethnography.

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